intelligence that knows how to exploit with superhuman efficiency the weaknesses, biases and addictions of the human mind?

Prior to the rise of AI, all the stories that shaped human societies originated in the imagination of a human being. For example, in October 2017 an anonymous user joined the website 4chan and identified themselves as Q. They claimed to have access to the most restricted or 'Q-level' classified information of the US government. Q began publishing cryptic posts that purported to reveal a worldwide conspiracy to destroy humanity. Q quickly gained a large online following. Their online messages, known as Q drops, were soon being collected, revered and interpreted as a sacred text. Inspired by earlier conspiracy theories going back to Kramer's *Hammer of the Witches*, the Q drops promoted a radical worldview according to which paedophiliac and cannibalistic witches who worship Satan have infiltrated the US administration and numerous other governments and institutions around the world.

This conspiracy theory – known as QAnon – was first disseminated online on American far-right websites and eventually gained millions of adherents worldwide. It is impossible to know the exact number, but when Facebook decided in August 2020 to take action against the spread of QAnon, it deleted or restricted more than ten thousand groups, pages and accounts associated with it, the largest of which had 230,000 followers. Independent investigations found that QAnon groups on Facebook had more than 4.5 million aggregate followers, though there was likely some overlap in the membership.[32]

QAnon has also had far-reaching consequences in the offline world. QAnon activists played an important role in the 6 January 2021 attack on the US Capitol.[33] In July 2020, a QAnon follower tried to storm the residence of the Canadian prime minister, Justin Trudeau, in order to 'arrest' him.[34] In October 2021, a French QAnon activist was charged with terrorism for planning a coup against the French government.[35] In the 2020 US congressional elections, twenty-two Republican candidates and two independents identified as QAnon followers.[36] Marjorie Taylor Greene, a Republican congresswoman representing Georgia, publicly said that many of Q's claims 'have really proven to be true',[37] and stated about Donald Trump, 'There's a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to take this global cabal of